

1900–1914

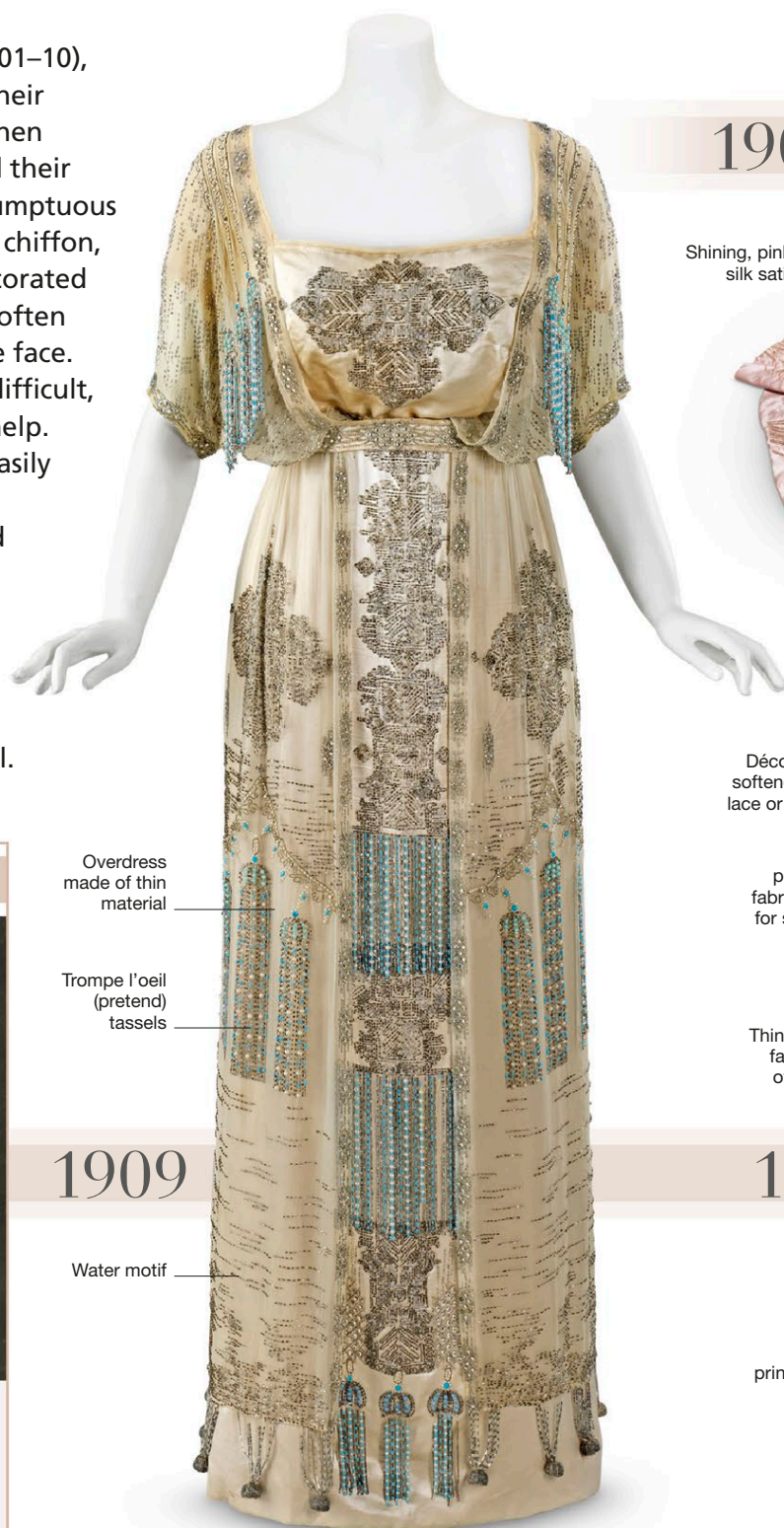
EVENING AND TEA GOWNS

Ladies of the Edwardian era (1901–10), whether young or old, bared their décolletage and upper arms when wearing evening dresses, but encased their lower arms in long evening gloves. Sumptuous fabrics such as silk satin, damask, and chiffon, usually in light, soft colours, were decorated with lace, rhinestones, and spangles, often highlighting a part of the body or the face. The gowns' many layers made them difficult, if not impossible, to put on without help. Often made of materials that could easily be damaged, eveningwear required decorous deportment. Tea gowns had emerged in the 1880s and continued to be a popular choice for receiving guests in the afternoon. The gowns were often made up of many layers of soft, light fabrics that were flattering but utterly impractical.

THE GIBSON GIRL



In the 1890s the American illustrator Charles Dana Gibson drew tall, slender-waisted, confident young women with layers of softly waved hair piled high on their heads. The "Gibson Girl" set an almost unobtainable beauty standard for the next two decades. The actress Camille Clifford (above) won a competition to find a living version of Gibson's creation.



Overdress made of thin material

Trompe l'oeil (pretend) tassels

1909

Water motif

Empire line Both the silk underdress and a fine outer layer are embroidered in coloured beads arranged in linear motifs that emphasize the statuesque feel of this gown. The three-dimensional tassels would move sensuously with the wearer.



Silk chiffon

Short lace sleeves

Asymmetric décolletage

1900

Shining, pink, silk satin

Satin gown This evening gown by the French House of Worth is embroidered with beads and rhinestones in a motif of ears of corn. Lace and chiffon soften the edges around the low décolletage and bare arms.



Décolletage softened with lace or chiffon

Embroidered peacock

Printed peacock fabric used for sleeves

Thin, gauzy fabric for overskirt

1910

Peacock printed in full on skirt

Peacock dress The blue and green of the printed and embroidered peacock's body and feathers in this dress are picked up in the waist sash, sleeve ends, and deep hem. The dress was bought in the little-known House of Weeks in Paris.